

side of the Mississippi River. On the afternoon of April 12, 1864 Confederate cavalry commanded by Lieutenant General Nathan Bedford Forrest “shot down, bayoneted, and put to the sword in cold blood” hundreds of Black soldiers as they tried to surrender. In response to the massacre, Black Federal volunteers adopted “Remember Fort Pillow” as their battle cry and thereafter sometimes engaged in their own excesses when dealing with apprehended Confederates.

Whether in a state-raised regiment, such as the famous 54th Massachusetts, or in one of the 166 regiments of the United States Colored Troops (USCT), soldiers in a Black regiment inverted the two principal Union war goals of their white comrades: they fought to free their people first, and preserve the Union second. As Frederick Douglass said, “The iron gate of our prison stands half open. One gallant rush from the North will fling it wide open, while four millions of our brothers and sisters shall march out into liberty.”

178,895 The number of men who enlisted in the USCT; at least 94,000 of them came from Southern states and 80,000 from the Northern states and territories; the rest had unknown origins.



107th Regiment U.S. Colored Infantry

Although Black soldiers fought for their country, they were not U.S. citizens. Frederick Douglass said that by bearing arms “no one can deny that [they have] earned the right to citizenship.”